

The macros you create have your name in comments

click the module name in the project explorer window. Delete the line that contains your name, and return to Word by pressing **[Alt] + [Q]**. You can also delete comments from the dialog box that comes up when you click **Tools > Macro > Macros**.

To restrict editing in Word, go to **Tools > Protect Document**. In Word 2002, a dialog box lets you choose to protect the document from tracked changes, comments and forms. Word 2003 shows you a task pane coming up with more options to set.

Here, choose specific formatting and editing restrictions, and choose exceptions. Thereafter, click 'Yes, Start Enforcing Protection.' Similarly, protect an Excel Workbook by setting a password, removing metadata, or by setting various options under **Tools > Protection**.

To remove metadata, go to **Tools > Options**. In General, delete contents from the 'User name' textbox, and the dialog box that appears at **File > Properties**.

If your PC is on a LAN, your username appears in the 'Last Saved' field. This occurs even if you've saved the file after deleting this data. A workaround is to copy the file to your local hard drive, get off the LAN and delete all data as specified above. In general, never open a document directly from the network location—always make a local copy.

To delete more, hidden metadata, delete all comments, headers, footers and hyperlinks from the document. Also, ensure no hidden cells are unprotected. To do so, first press **[Ctrl] + [Shift] + [Space]** to select all cells. Now, show all rows and columns by going to **Format > Row > Unhide** and **Format > Column > Unhide** respectively.

Embedded objects such as a Word document have different properties than that of the workbook. Remove metadata for them separately. There's another way out: select the object and cut it (**[Ctrl] + [X]**). Then, go to **Edit > Paste Special**, and choose 'Metafile' format. Press OK to paste it without any metadata. However, you now won't be able to edit the object. Finally, delete custom views by going to **View > Custom Views**. You should also remove comments from macros.

More protection

In Excel, the layers of protection that control data access to your workbook are not true security features: you can prevent



Feeling protected?

Security is a serious issue, and not just for system administrators. What we've discussed here is a drop in the ocean. Share what you do to make your files secure. Drop us a mail at readersletters@jasubhai.com or post your comments at the Digit Readers' Forum—www.thinkdigit.com/forum.

the original data from being changed, but you can't stop anyone from copying data from workbooks. These are thus useful only, for example, when you want to avoid someone accidentally making changes to the data.

To prevent anyone from making changes to any cells, go to **Tools > Protection** and click 'Protect Sheet.' This dialog box also allows you to set more options, such as a password to unprotect the sheet, and individual changes that users are allowed to make. This applies to all cells. To unlock specific cells, select them, right-click and choose Format Cells. Then, go to the Protection tab and remove the Locked checkmark.

Go to **Tools > Protection > Allow users to edit ranges**. Here, define the ranges of the cells that all users are allowed to modify. Click Permissions to choose who can modify the contents.

This is different from the aforementioned lock-unlock method, since it's applicable for different users in Windows 2000 and XP. Secondly, the selected users can edit these ranges without a password. These options come into effect only when you've protected the sheet.

Protecting PowerPoint

Metadata in PowerPoint presentations can be deleted in ways similar to those used for Excel. Go to **Tools > Options** and, from the 'General' tab, delete the information you don't want. Then, go to **File > Properties** and delete information across different tabs.

If you're on a network, make a local copy of the presentation, disconnect from the network and then delete this information. Disable fast saves by going to **Tools > Options > Save** and removing the checkmark that says 'Allow fast saves.' Also delete comments, headers, footers, hyperlinks and comments in macro code as with Excel. Give the same treatment to embedded objects as with Excel, too. ■

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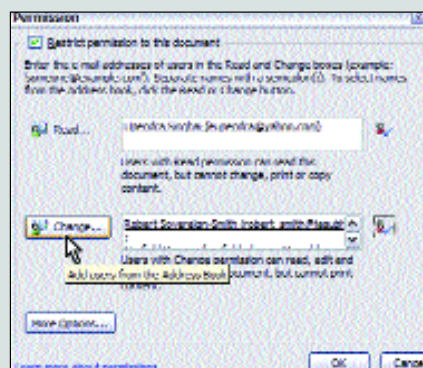
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Information Rights Management in Office 2003

Microsoft Office 2003 Professional allows you to restrict the permissions for the documents you create, using Information Rights Management. You can restrict access to a document even after you send it to someone.

To create restricted content with Office 2003, go to **File > Permissions** and select 'Restrict Permission As'. You are asked to install the latest version of the Windows Digital Rights Management Client—a small 345 KB download. You will be asked to sign up for a free trial account on Microsoft's rights management server. Now you see a dialog box where you can specify the .NET passport addresses of the users, and the permissions you want to give them—Read, Change and Full Control.

When users open this file, they will have to sign in using their .NET passport account.



Set the .NET passport identities and permissions for all users allowed to access your file

The extent to which they can work on the file depends solely on the permissions you had set when creating the file.